

CORE FORMULA

Name what you know -> Name what you do not know -> Own the gap with confidence

MINIMUM VIABLE MOVE

When you do not know something, say so directly and then name what you do know. Do not bluff and do not apologise for not knowing.

BEST FOR

- High-stakes situations where bluffing would be worse than admitting uncertainty
- Expert or interview contexts where credibility is on the line
- Any situation where you are pressed for an answer you do not have
- Building long-term credibility by being reliably honest

PHRASE BANK

Confident Uncertainty Phrases · Owning not knowing

- "I do not know the answer to that — and I do not want to guess."
- "I am not certain about this and I would rather say so than bluff."
- "That is outside what I can say confidently."
- "My honest answer is: I do not know."
- "I can tell you what I do know, which is X. I cannot tell you Y."
- "I do not have that information in front of me."
- "I would rather admit that and come back with the right answer."
- "That is a better question than I can currently answer."

Bounded Answer · Saying what you can say

- "What I can say is..."
- "What I know for certain is..."
- "I can confirm X — I cannot confirm Y."
- "My best estimate is X, but I want to flag that I am not certain."
- "I will give you my best current read — with the caveat that..."

Quick Admissions · Short, unapologetic not-knowing

- "I do not know — I will find out."
- "Not sure. Let me check."
- "Good question — I do not have it to hand."
- "Cannot say yet."
- "I would be guessing."
- "No idea — yet."

Calibrated Updates · Labelling confidence in work reporting

- "Here is what is confirmed, and here is what is still assumption."
- "I am confident on cost, less so on timeline — the risk sits there."
- "Two things I know and one I do not — let me take them in that order."
- "I would put roughly seventy per cent confidence on that estimate."
- "The honest status: on track for scope, uncertain on the integration date."
- "The data supports the first claim; on the second we are still guessing, and I want to label it as guessing."

Warm Honesty · Not knowing, said with care

- "I honestly do not know what I would do in your shoes."
- "I do not have an answer — but I am happy to sit with the question with you."
- "I wish I could promise it will be fine. What I can promise is that you will not face it alone."
- "I do not know enough to advise you, but I know enough to listen."
- "My honest answer is that I am not sure — and I would rather give you that than something polished."

WEAK -> BETTER -> BEST

1. Weak: Bluffing: 'Yes, I believe that would be around...'
Better: I am not entirely sure — my best guess would be...
Best: I do not know that. I can find out by X and come back to you.
2. Weak: Apologising excessively for not knowing
Better: I am sorry, I do not have that.
Best: I do not know — and I do not want to guess. What I can say is...
3. Weak: Saying you do not know but then speculating anyway
Better: I am not sure, but maybe...
Best: Stop at 'I do not know.' Add only what you genuinely know.

DECISION TREE

If You are asked something you do not know

Say you do not know. Name what you do know. Offer to find the answer.
"I do not know that. What I can say is X. I can check and confirm by end of day."

If You have a partial answer and are tempted to fill in the gap

Give the partial answer and name the boundary.
"I know X but I am not confident about Y — I do not want to guess at that part."

If You are an expert and feel pressure to have all the answers

Your credibility is built on accuracy, not omniscience. Name what you do not know.
"In my field, the honest answer here is that we do not know yet."

If They seem disappointed you do not know

Hold the uncertainty rather than backfilling with speculation.
"I understand you need a clearer answer — I would rather give you the right one."

SCENARIOS

Interview question outside your knowledge

State the boundary of your knowledge confidently. Offer what you can. — "That is at the edge of my area — I do not want to give you an unreliable answer. What I can say is..."

Client asks a technical question you cannot answer

Admit the gap, confirm what you know, commit to finding out. — "I do not have that number with me — I will confirm it today. What I can confirm is X."

Meeting where you are expected to have information you do not

Do not pretend. Name what you have and what you are missing. — "I do not have the full picture on this yet — I can give you what I have and flag the gaps."

Being asked for an estimate you cannot give confidently

Give a range with explicit uncertainty rather than a false precision. — "My rough estimate is X — but I want to flag that I am not confident in that figure."

WHEN NOT TO USE

- When the audience needs a definitive answer to proceed and further uncertainty will paralyse decision-making.
- In contexts where expressing uncertainty is read as incompetence — some cultures and hierarchies require stated confidence.

- When you actually are certain — false modesty obscures clear information.

7-DAY PRACTICE DRILL

Day 1 — Spot the bluff

Notice one moment today when you gave a confident answer you were not actually certain about.

Day 2 — Name the boundary

In one conversation, say 'I do not know' rather than bluffing or hedging.

Day 3 — What you do know

After admitting uncertainty, name specifically what you do know — no broader than what you can stand behind.

Day 4 — Commit to finding out

After every 'I do not know', offer a specific time by which you will come back with the answer.

Day 5 — Tone check

Say 'I do not know' confidently — not apologetically. Notice how it lands differently.

Day 6 — Expert context

Use confident uncertainty in a context where you are expected to be the expert.

Day 7 — Calibration

Did 'I do not know' land well? Did you follow up on things you committed to check? Did credibility improve?

AFTER-ACTION CHECKLIST

- Did I say 'I do not know' directly rather than hedging or bluffing?
- Did I name what I do know clearly?
- Did I own the gap confidently rather than apologetically?
- Did I commit to finding the answer and follow through?
- Did I avoid speculating after admitting I did not know?
- Did my tone stay grounded rather than nervous?
- Did people seem to trust my honesty rather than lose confidence in me?